# Nutty Putty Guy

## The Case of the Autographed Baseball

Ring! “Hello, Super Hero Hotline. This is Fiona. How may I help you? Really? You do? I’ll send someone right away.”

Fiona got off the phone and called for a super hero. After all, that was her job. She ran the Super Hero Hotline, the place to call if you need a super hero to solve a problem. Now, if you want a super hero that flies, is super strong, bullet-proof, or can shape change, the Super-Hero Hotline isn’t the place to call. Those types of heroes are all gainfully employed saving a metropolis.

The Super Hero Hotline employs heroes with lesser powers, like changing everything they touch blue, shooting marshmallow goo all over, or always having exact change when they need it. For some cases, that's the best type of super hero to have. After all, being super strong doesn't help when you're getting on a city bus and are short a nickel.

"Heroes!" Fiona called. "I need a hero." She looked around to see who her choices were and chose Nutty Putty Guy. "You're needed at the school immediately."

"But I already graduated," Nutty Putty Guy argued. He then ran out the door without even waiting for a briefing.

He rode his skateboard to the school, ran it up a hill, flipped over, and landed on the playground, face down in the grass. "Nutty Putty Guy here," he announced as he jumped up. "Where's the trouble?"

The first graders on the playground had no idea, but they were excited about seeing a real super-hero. He, of course, wore spandex shorts, a hoodie with NP on it, a mid-length glow in the dark cape,

and a baseball cap. The first graders were upset because it was day so they couldn't see his cape glow.

Once he got all of them off him, he called Fiona on his cell phone and asked where to go. She told him to go to room 214, so Nutty Putty Guy headed into the building.

He was upset that the principal wouldn't let him ride his skateboard down the hall. What kind of super-hero walks into a classroom? He had to make an entrance.

He walked down the hallway, opened the door, ran into the classroom and jumped as hard as he could. He flew across the room, turned mid-air, and hit the wall, which his back stuck to.

"I am Nutty Putty Guy!" he announced, and all the students cheered. He pulled himself off the wall and landed on the floor. He posed and asked, "What is the problem?"

A small blond-haired boy stepped up. "Jeremy took my baseball," he said. "I brought it for show and tell, and he took it."

"I did not!" Jeremy insisted.

“Children,” Mrs. Getch said. “Please don’t fight in front of the super-hero. Just let him know what happened.”

The blond boy spoke again. “I’m Scott. I brought my autographed baseball for show and tell today. All of us were going to bring in something to do with sports. I brought in my special baseball autographed by Roy Mann. He’s my favorite short stop ever. By the time show and tell was over, my baseball was gone. I think Jeremy took it because he’s a big fan of Roy Mann and said he’d love to have it when I showed it.”

“I didn’t take it,” Jeremy insisted. “I brought a soccer trophy from my last season. I didn’t steal your ball. You can check my desk and backpack.”

He proceeded to check the backpack and desk but found nothing. That didn’t rule Jeremy out because he could have hidden it someplace. “Hmm, Let me think,” Nutty Putty Guy told them.

After a moment of thought, he asked if there were any others who brought baseballs for show and tell. There were four.

Benji brought a baseball autographed by Roger Matthews, the pitcher for the Howler Monkeys. He said that it obviously wasn't Scott's ball because it was signed by a different person. Besides, Benji sat across the room from Scott, so he couldn't have reached it. Nutty Putty Guy picked up the ball and rolled it up and down his arm. Then he rolled it up one arm and down the other. The class cheered at his skill, but laughed that Roger Matthews backwards was left on his skin everywhere he had rolled the ball. He rubbed his skin to get the words off.

Aaron showed his baseball next. It had no name on it, just a plain ball. Aaron said the ball was special because his dad hit a home run in a championship game with it in college. He was lucky to get it. He sat by Scott, so he could have reached Scott's ball, but he couldn't have erased the permanent marker it was signed in, and his desk was clear of the ball. Nutty Putty Guy did even more tricks with Aaron's ball. He liked it because it didn't leave marks on his skin. He rolled it around his arms, across his shoulders, and down a leg. He had a great advantage in this type

of trick because the ball stuck to his skin, but not so tightly that it wouldn't roll.

Max was next. He had a ball autographed by his favorite player LeRoy Manning. Max said LeRoy played first base for the Flying Lizards. Nutty Putty Guy took that ball and entertained the children. Again, they were amazed at his tricks and laughed at the words all over his skin. This one left the letters "Le" and "ing" backward all over his skin.

Next, Matthew showed his ball. It wasn't autographed. He said he caught it when Jack Taylor hit a home run last year playing against the Purple Hamsters. Again, Nutty Putty Guy did tricks for the children with the ball.

"Please," Mrs. Getch pleaded. "Can't we just get on with this? I still have a lesson to teach." Nutty Putty Guy gave the ball back and got back to the case.

He had everyone search the room for the ball, but no one found it. They looked especially hard through the student's desk who sat beside Scott, but the ball wasn't there. The ball wasn't anywhere. They did find some interesting things –

baseball cards, toys, the homework Jake swore his dog ate last week... but not the ball.

“We’ve already searched the room,” Mrs. Getch explained. “If it were easy, I would have solved it, and Scott wouldn’t have had to call you. Now, please hurry.

“Has anyone entered or left the room since Scott showed the ball?” Nutty Putty Guy asked. The teacher said no one had entered or left, but that several of the children had gone to the bathroom that was in the classroom. Jeremy got up to get a tissue, and Mark went to his backpack to get his gymnastics medal. Other than that the children had stayed in their seats.

“I told you Jeremy did it,” Scott accused. “He picked up my ball when he went to get the tissue. He just hid it so well that we can’t find it.”

“Actually,” Nutty Putty Guy announced. “I know where your ball is and who took it.”

“Really?” Mrs. Getch exclaimed. “Please tell us so I can get on with my lesson.”

“I’ll tell you,” Nutty Putty Guy announced rather theatrically. “It was...”

# Who Stole Scott’s Ball?